perfectly. Eventually, the team made a point of using that particular bathroom and we even went on to win the game!

Another key difference from international cricket concerns culture. Almost all the players in the Indian team come from a similar background and are well versed in the Indian system of playing the game by the time they make the national team. In the IPL, there can be vast cultural differences between a rookie Indian youngster and an established international stalwart, which makes the need for team bonding all the more important. Looking after the youngsters and making sure they are not overawed are added responsibilities for team owners, senior management and senior players. I have particularly enjoyed mentoring young Indian talent and trying to act as a bridge between them and the international professionals playing for the Mumbai Indians.

Impact on Indian cricket

That the IPL has had a profound impact on Indian cricket is beyond doubt. The benefits are obvious, but there are also a few concerns that need to be taken seriously if the tournament is to evolve further in the years to come.

On the plus side, the IPL has contributed to improving international player relations. The best example is the case of Andrew Symonds and Harbhajan Singh. In the fourth season of the IPL in 2011, Symonds and Bhajji played for the Mumbai Indians. I clearly remember our first meeting with Andrew when he joined the team. I told him that the Sydney controversy of 2008 was in the past and that neither I nor Harbhajan would ever refer to the incident in our dealings with Andrew. Andrew, for his part, reciprocated the camaraderie and we became good friends. We played some really good matches side by side and I am sure when we meet next we will share the same chemistry.

Since the start of the IPL, none of the India–Australia series have featured the kind of acrimony on show during the 2008 tour. In IPL season six in 2013, for example, I had the opportunity to play with Ricky Ponting. Ricky and I had played international cricket against each other for years but the only interaction we had had before playing together for the Mumbai Indians was the occasional hello. Suddenly we were sharing the same dressing room and opening the batting together. It was